

Margaret Deefholts, a Canadian writer with Anglo-Indian roots, recalls, "... the New Year's Eve gala was a stellar event with the women resplendent in their *darzi*-made [tailor-made] gowns, and the men toggged up in suits and ties."

## **Independence anxieties**

The freedom movement caused upheavals in the lives of the community and were further exacerbated by Independence. Foundationally defined as the offspring of the colonial masters, and the belief that many in the community shared, of being more European than Indian, led to sharply drawn lines, leaving the Anglo-Indian reeling from social and economic prejudice. Half of the community emigrated following Independence. Today, there is a sizeable population of Anglo-Indians around the world. In India, their population has shrunk from half a million in the 1940s to about 1,50,000.

## **DURAND INSTITUTE**

The first ever recreational club of the railways in India, the Durand Institute, now rechristened the Vivekananda Institute was set up in 1878 in Asansol, West Bengal by the East Indian Railway (EIR). It was named after Sir Mortimer Durand who served as India's foreign secretary from 1884 to 1894. It has a cathedral-like structure with a tower that juts out like a steeple, and Gothic arches. A picture of sophistication, it became the venue for all the major EIR social and cultural activities. High-ranking EIR officials would travel to Asansol to revel in the Institute's Christmas celebrations. Post-Independence, it suffered from neglect and decay. The Eastern Railway undertook a massive renovation exercise and restored the building to its old splendour. It was reopened on 15 August 2018, India's Independence Day.